Grünfeld Defense

ECO A56-E60 | 59 named lines | King's Indian / Grünfeld / Benoni family

In one sentence: Let White build a big center and attack it: dynamic, double-edged and rich in attacking chances for Black.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, castle, ...e5, ...f5: attack White's king while White attacks yours.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Bg4

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes, castles, then strikes with ...e5 or ...c5.
2. Classical KID: after d5 the center locks; White plays on the queenside (c5), Black on the kingside (...f5-f4, ...g5).
3. Grünfeld: Black attacks the center with ...d5, ...Nxd5 and ...c5.
4. Benoni: asymmetrical; Black plays ...b5, ...Re8 and ...Nbd7.
5. The g7 bishop becomes a monster when the center closes.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.67** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best: Be3.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Hypermodern: Black fianchettoes and lets White build c4/d4/e4. KID: locked centre (d5/e5) with ...f5 against c5. Grünfeld: Black attacks the centre with pieces and ...c5. Benoni: asymmetrical with queenside majority.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles kingside and attacks it with pawns (...f5, ...g5) or keeps it solid; White often castles long to counter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7 (the monster), knights e8/d7/c6, rooks f8/e8. White: Be3/Bg5, Nf3, Qd2, space.
4. Main middlegame plan?	KID: ...e5 and ...f5 kingside play against White's c5/queenside space. Grünfeld: attack d4 with ...c5/...Nc6/...Bg4.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants space and a queenside break; Black wants a kingside pawn storm or a central counterblow.

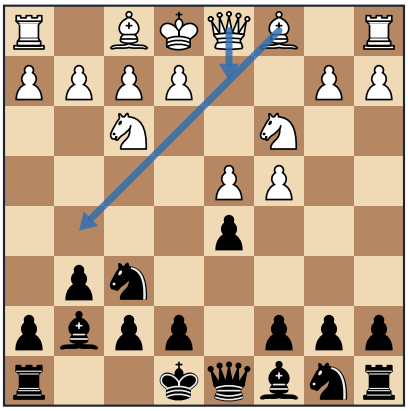
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Bg4

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... g6	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... d5	Grunfeld counter. Occupies the center with a pawn.
4. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
4... Bg7	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
5. Qb3	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
5... dxc4	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
6. Qxc4	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
6... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
7. e4	Big center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
7... Bg4	Develops the bishop to g4.



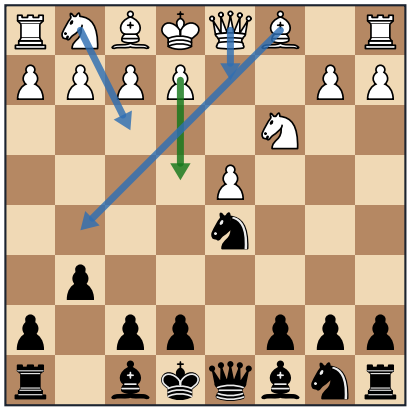
After 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6



After g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

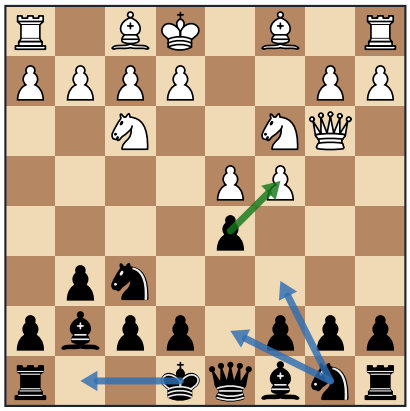


Position after the line

Exchange Variation D85 | 17 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5`

Stockfish: **+0.28** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: e4.
What to look for: d4 (center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Modern Exchange Variation, Spassky Variation, Larsen Variation, Nadanian Attack

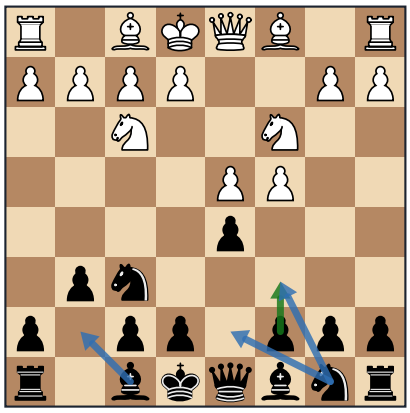


Position after the line

Russian Variation D96 | 12 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3`

Stockfish: **+0.42** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: dxc4.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Smyslov Variation, Accelerated Variation, Byrne Variation, Hungarian Variation

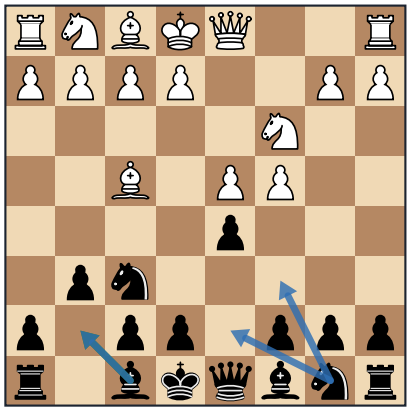


Position after the line

Three Knights Variation D90 | 9 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.49** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: c6.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Burille Variation, Petrosian System, Hungarian Attack, Hungarian Variation



Position after the line

Brinckmann Attack D82 | 6 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4`

Stockfish: **+0.25** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Bg7.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Grünfeld Gambit, Reshevsky Gambit, Grünfeld Gambit Accepted



Position after the line

Lutikov Variation D80 | 2 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.f3`

Stockfish: **-0.48** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: c5.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Murrey Attack



Position after the line

Gibbon Gambit D80 | 1 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.g4`

Stockfish: **-0.62** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: dxc4.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)

Detailed repertoire notes

Grunfeld Defense (D70-D99, Black)

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Nf3 c5 8.Be3 Qa5 9.Qd2 Bg4 10.Rb1 O-O
11.Be2 cxd4 12.cxd4 Nc6
```

Idea: Allow a big pawn center and attack it with pieces, ...c5 and the g7 bishop.

Structure: White has a broad center (c3, d4, e4); Black has a flexible, mobile piece setup.

Pieces: Bg7 hits d4, queen a5, knight c6, bishop g4, rooks c8/d8.

Plan: Pressure d4, trade pieces, and attack the center before White can consolidate; endgames favor Black if White's center is weak.

King: Castle after ...Bg7; avoid early ...h6 or ...g5. **Opponent:** A big center (c3-d4-e4) and kingside pressure; hold d4.

Watch out: The Exchange and Russian lines are theory-heavy; the pawn center can be dangerous if you slip.

Expert and coach view

Fischer and Kasparov used the King's Indian Defense as a main weapon.

What a coach would tell you

Learn the KID by structure: in the Classical, count the pawn storm race; in the Sämisch, the structure is different (...c5). Make sure you know your plan versus Bg5, h3 and f3 setups.

Why play it

Let White build a big center and attack it: dynamic, double-edged and rich in attacking chances for Black.

Typical mistakes

- Pushing ...f5 before development is complete.
- Allowing White's c5 break without counterplay.
- Playing ...exd4 too early and giving White an easy central grip.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bg5 and Bxf6 followed by Nd5 when Black's knight leaves f6.
- Early e5 pushes by White hitting the unprotected d6 pawn.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Middlegames are sharp; endgames are less common, but a solid pawn structure and open g7 bishop help Black.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Grünfeld Defense (all lines)** — D80
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5`
  - **Brinckmann Attack** — D82
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Bf4`
    - **Grünfeld Gambit** — D83
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 -> 4...Bg7 5.e3 O-O`
      - **Capablanca Variation** — D83
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 Bg7 5.e3 O-O -> 6.Rc1`
      - **Botvinnik Variation** — D83
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 Bg7 5.e3 O-O -> 6.Rc1 c5 7.dxc5 Be6`
    - **Reshevsky Gambit** — D83
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Rc1 O-O 6.e3 c5 7.dxc5 Qa5`
    - **Grünfeld Gambit Accepted** — D84
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 -> 4...Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.cxd5 Nxd5 7.Nxd5 Qxd5 8.Bxc7`
  - **Gibbon Gambit** — D80
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.g4`
  - **Lutikov Variation** — D80
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.f3`
    - **Murrey Attack** — D80
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.f3 -> 4...c5 5.cxd5 Nxd5 6.Na4`
  - **Stockholm Variation** — D80
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Bg5`
  - **Three Knights Variation** — D90
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Nf3`
    - **Burille Variation** — D94
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.e3`
      - **Reversed Tarrasch** — A56
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.e3 g6 4.Nc3 Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be2 cxd4 7.exd4 d5 8.O-O Nc6`
    - **Hungarian Attack** — D92
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.Bf4`
    - **Petrosian System** — D91
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.Bg5`
    - **Hungarian Variation** — D93
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.Bf4 O-O 6.e3`
    - **Paris Variation** — D94
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.Bd3`
    - **Vienna Variation** — D95
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.Qb3`
  - **Zaitsev Gambit** — D80
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.h4`
  - **Counterthrust Variation** — E60
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.g3 Bg7 4.Bg2 d5`
  - **Exchange Variation** — D85
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.cxd5 Nxd5`
    - **Nadanian Attack** — D85
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.Na4`
    - **Classical Variation** — D86
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4`
    - **Modern Exchange Variation** — D85
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Nf3`
      - **Kramnik's Line** — D85
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.c4 Bg7 4.Nc3 d5 5.cxd5 Nxd5 6.e4 Nxc3 7.bxc3 c5 8.h3`
      - **Pawn Grab Line** — D85
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Nf3 -> 7...c5 8.Rb1 O-O 9.Be2 Nc6 10.d5 Bxc3`
    - **Larsen Variation** — D86
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4 O-O 8.Ne2 Qd7`
    - **Simagin's Improved Variation** — D86
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4 O-O 8.Ne2 Nc6`

Simagin's Lesser Variation D86
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4 O-O 8.Ne2 b6

Spassky Variation D87
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4 c5 8.Ne2 O-O

Seville Variation D87
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4 c5 8.Ne2 Nc6 9.Be3 O-O 10.O-O Bg4 11.f3 N…

Sokolsky Variation D89
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 -> 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Bc4 c5 8.Ne2 O-O 9.O-O Nc6 10.Be3 Bg4 11.f3 Na…

Flohr Variation D90
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qa4

Russian Variation D96
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3

Accelerated Variation D81
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Qb3

Byrne Variation D97
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Nc6

Hungarian Variation D97
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 a6

Levenfish Variation D97
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 b6

Prins Variation D97
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Na6

Smyslov Variation D98
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Bg4

Szabo Variation D97
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 c6

Yugoslav Variation D99
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Bg4 8.Be3 Nfd7 9.Qb3 c5

Keres Variation D98
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 -> 5...dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Bg4 8.Be3 Nfd7 9.Be2 Nb6 10.Qd3 Nc6 11.O…

Makogonov Variation D94
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.b4

Opocensky Variation D94
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.Bd2

Botvinnik Variation D95
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.Qb3 e6

Lundin Variation D80
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.Bg5 Ne4 5.Nxe4 dxe4 6.Qd2 c5

Flohr Defense D94
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 g6 5.Nf3 Bg7 6.Bd3 O-O 7.O-O Bf5

Smyslov Defense D94
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 g6 5.Nf3 Bg7 6.Bd3 O-O 7.O-O Bg4

Pachman Variation D95
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 -> 4.e3 Bg7 5.Qb3 dxc4 6.Bxc4 O-O 7.Nf3 Nbd7 8.Ng5

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 dxc4
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Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nc3 -> e4 -> Nf3
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, castle, ...e5, ...f5: attack White's king while White attacks yours.

2. KID: ...e5 and ...f5 kingside play against White's c5/queenside space. Grünfeld: attack d4 with ...c5/...Nc6/...Bg4.

3. White wants space and a queenside break; Black wants a kingside pawn storm or a central counterblow.

Pawn structure in one line

Hypermodern: Black fianchettoes and lets White build c4/d4/e4. KID: locked centre (d5/e5) with ...f5 against c5. Grünfeld: Black attacks the centre with pieces and ...c5. Benoni: asymmetrical with queenside majority.